‘What kind of prime minister stands at the Red Fort and talks about toilet building?’ This was quintessential Modi—breaking with tradition, almost challenging the ruling class to reorder its priorities.

He even threw up a ‘Make in India’ catchline, an invitation to the world to make India a manufacturing hub. He called for a ten-year moratorium on divisive politics and asked for parents to check rising crimes against women by educating their sons. And yes, he did promise to disband the Planning Commission. The tedium of using the 15 August speech to pay ritualistic obeisance to past achievements was forsaken. Instead, Modi was offering a glimpse at a future aimed at growth and harmony. The rousing speech received a thumbs up—Television Audience Meter (TAM) ratings show that it was watched by a viewership three times higher than the 2013 Independence Day speech. Modi had pressed all the right buttons—now, importantly, he needs to walk the talk.

Only a few days before Modi’s virtuoso performance, his general election Man of the Match, Amit Shah, was also given his reward—he was made the BJP president. For someone who, just eighteen months ago, was facing an extended prison sentence in a fake encounter case, it was an astonishing turnaround. Indeed, never before have two leaders from the same state outside of the Hindi heartland come to dominate national politics in such a sudden and dramatic manner. As a bureaucrat laughingly told me, ‘I hope that we now at least get a half-decent Gujarati restaurant in Delhi!’

Shah has his task cut out—he has to be a bridge between party and government but, importantly, also ensure that his winning formula of the general elections is sustained in the state elections as well. In his first speech as party president, he set out the BJP’s goal. ‘We must capture power from Jammu and Kashmir to Kerala, from Nagaland to Gujarat.’ It is an ambitious project, but after his stunning success in UP, Shah seems to believe he has the organizational machine to deliver the results. Certainly, his eye for detail and micromanagement mark him out as an ideal election strategist.

And yet, the Shah model of fighting elections has also thrown up real concerns of a worrying revival of communally divisive politics. His